



Theme Trackers

Grade 7 • North Carolina • Reading

RL.7.2

Determine a theme of a literary text, analyze how it develops across the text, and write an objective summary. An 80-minute block-period packet with warm-up, guided practice, partner discussion, independent practice, small-group work, and a full answer key.

PRINT • TEACH • REVISIT



Plan the 80-minute block

Level and alignment

Grade 7 · North Carolina · Reading; RL.7.2 — Determine a theme of a text and analyze its development over the course of the text; provide an objective summary of the text.

What is included

Cover; teacher guide; vocabulary and lesson preview; original passage; warm-up (2 items); guided practice with organizer (4 items); partner discussion (3 items); independent practice (6 items); small-group intervention and enrichment (4 items); exit ticket; complete answer key; access and sources page.

Suggested pacing (80 minutes)

Warm-up 8 min · passage + guided practice 25 min · partner discussion 12 min · independent practice 20 min · small-group work 10 min · exit ticket 5 min.

Preparation

Print student pages separately from the answer key. Review the passage and organizer before class. No outside novel or paid app required.

Student directions

Read the passage carefully. Use evidence from the text to support every answer. Quote or closely paraphrase the text and name the paragraph.



Before you read

Key vocabulary

Lesson focus

A theme is a message about life the story teaches, not just its topic. An objective summary reports only what happens, in order, without your opinions or added details. Track how a character's actions or thinking change from the beginning to the end to find how the theme develops.

Model 1 — Topic: friendship. Possible theme?

A true friend supports you even when it is inconvenient — a complete sentence describing a lesson, not just a one-word topic.

Model 2 — Is "the team lost the first three games" an objective summary sentence or an opinion?

Objective — it reports a plot fact without judgment. "The team foolishly lost" would add opinion.



WARM-UP

Warm-up · Before you read

Answer using what you already know. Five minutes.

1. What is the topic of this story in one or two words?

2. State a possible theme of the story as a full sentence.



Second String

1. Renata had played second-string goalkeeper for two seasons. She knew the starting keeper's habits better than her own: how Coach Yu warmed up, which drills the team ran on rainy days, how long the equipment closet stuck before it opened.
2. In the third game of the season, the starting keeper, Bea, rolled her ankle in warm-ups. Coach Yu looked down the bench. "Renata, you're in."
3. Renata's first save came in the ninth minute, a low shot she barely reached. Her second came in the twentieth, a header she caught cleanly. By halftime her hands were raw from the gloves, but the score was still 0-0.
4. In the second half, an opposing forward broke free. Renata came off her line too early, and the ball slipped past her into the net. She heard someone on the bench groan. She did not look at them.
5. "Reset," Coach Yu called from the sideline. Renata nodded, more to herself than to him, and moved back into position for the next play.
6. With four minutes left, the same forward broke free again. This time Renata held her line, waited, and smothered the shot at the forward's feet. The whistle blew. Her team had lost 1-0, but she had made six saves in her first start.
7. After the game, Bea, on crutches, met her at the equipment closet. "You held your line that last time," Bea said. "That's the part I still mess up." Renata realized she had spent two seasons learning the game by watching someone she had assumed was simply better than her.
8. The next week, Coach Yu posted the lineup. Renata's name was listed first.



Guided practice · Evidence organizer

Work through this organizer together before independent practice.

It Says

Quote or closely paraphrase the text.

It Means

Explain the evidence in your own words.

And So

State the inference or analysis it supports.

1. What explicit event starts Renata's chance to play?

2. How does Renata react to her first mistake in paragraph 4? Cite the text.

3. What does Coach Yu say after her mistake, and what does it suggest about the theme?

4. How does Renata's action in paragraph 6 show change or growth from paragraph 4?



Partner discussion

Discuss each question with a partner before writing a joint response.

1. What does Bea's comment in paragraph 7 reveal about Renata's past view of herself?

2. How does the story's ending develop the theme? Cite evidence.

3. Which theme fits the story better: "Winning is the only measure of success" or "Growth can come from failure that leads to recovery"? Explain with evidence.



Independent practice

Work independently. Cite evidence from the text in every answer.

1. Write one objective sentence summarizing paragraphs 1-2 (no opinions).

2. Write one objective sentence summarizing paragraph 4 (no opinions).

3. Identify one word in this draft summary that is an opinion, not a fact: "Renata bravely and skillfully made her first save."



Independent practice

Work independently. Cite evidence from the text in every answer.

4. Write an objective one-sentence summary of the story's ending.

5. Why is "Renata was clearly the best player on the team" not appropriate for an objective summary?

6. Combine paragraphs 3, 4, and 6 into one two-sentence objective summary.



Small-group work

Use with students who need additional support.

1. How does Bea's appearance on crutches at the end connect to the theme? Cite evidence.

2. Trace one specific way the theme develops from the middle to the end of the story.



Small-group work

Use with students ready for additional challenge.

1. Is "the team lost 1-0" objective or subjective? Explain.

2. Write a two-sentence objective summary of the whole story.

Exit ticket

Answer independently to show what you learned today.

1. State the theme in one sentence and support it with one piece of cited evidence.



Exit ticket · self-assessment

Rate today's work:

4 — I can teach this to someone else.

3 — I can do this independently.

2 — I can do this with help.

1 — I need to revisit this with my teacher.



Answer key

1. Soccer, or goalkeeping — the general subject, not yet a full theme statement.
2. Preparation lets you rise to an opportunity even when it comes unexpectedly — or an equivalent full-sentence life lesson supported by the story.
3. Bea rolls her ankle in warm-ups before the third game.
4. She does not look at the bench when someone groans; she does not react outwardly to the error.
5. He says "Reset," suggesting the theme includes recovering focus after a setback rather than dwelling on it.

Accept equivalent, well-supported alternative answers throughout.



Answer key

6. In paragraph 4 she comes off her line too early and is scored on; in paragraph 6 she holds her line and stops the same kind of attack, showing she adjusted her approach.
7. Renata had assumed Bea was simply better than her, but Bea says holding the line is something she herself still struggles with, showing Renata underestimated her own growth.
8. Coach Yu lists Renata's name first on the new lineup, showing that her preparation and improvement during the game earned a lasting opportunity, not just a one-game fill-in.
9. "Growth can come from failure that leads to recovery" fits better; the team loses 1-0, yet Renata's recovery after her mistake and Bea's comment show personal growth mattered more than the score.
10. Renata had played second-string goalkeeper for two seasons, and when the starting keeper was injured in the third game, the coach put her in.

Accept equivalent, well-supported alternative answers throughout.



Answer key

11. An opposing forward broke free, Renata left her line early, and the ball went into the net.
12. Bravely (or skillfully) — these describe the writer's judgment of the save, not an observable fact from the text.
13. Renata made six saves in her first start, her team lost 1-0, and the coach listed her name first on the next lineup.
14. It is an opinion and an overstatement not directly supported by the text, which only shows her performance in one game.
15. Renata made two saves in the first half to keep the score at 0-0. In the second half she was scored on once after leaving her line early, but she recovered to stop the same forward late in the game.

Accept equivalent, well-supported alternative answers throughout.



Answer key

16. It shows the story values Bea's honest acknowledgment of Renata's growth ("That's the part I still mess up"), reinforcing that skill and confidence develop over time for both characters.

17. In the middle, Renata's mistake in paragraph 4 shows a gap in her readiness; by paragraph 6 she applies what she learned to succeed in the same situation, showing the theme of growth developing through direct experience.

18. Objective — it is a verifiable fact stated in the text, without added judgment.

19. After the starting goalkeeper was injured, a second-string player got her first start and made several saves despite one early mistake. Her team lost by one goal, but her performance earned her the top spot on the next lineup.

20. Answers vary; require a complete theme statement (a lesson, not just a topic) plus one specific, correctly cited detail from the story that supports it.

Accept equivalent, well-supported alternative answers throughout.



Access, sources, and license

AIG

Ask for a second interpretation, a counterexample, or a student-written item at the same rigor, with an explanation of the choice.

504

Follow the individual plan: extended time, breaks, enlarged print, reduced copying, or an alternate response method as documented.

EC

Pre-teach key vocabulary before reading. Model the first guided-practice item aloud. Accept oral or dictated responses when appropriate.

ESL

Preview key vocabulary with examples. Allow brief home-language discussion before independent writing. Provide sentence starters for open-response items.

Official alignment source • accessed September 18, 2026

RL.7.2 — Determine a theme of a text and analyze its development over the course of the text; provide an objective summary of the text.. The objective is original wording describing a focused part of the standard.

NC ELA Standard Course of Study, Grade 7: <https://www.dpi.nc.gov/documents/publications/catalog/>

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